



Apple’s photographs, in matching rounded frames. The pair and the closed case are from apple.com/airpods-5. The close-up is the speaker mesh from the Apple Store gallery. On the plates that follow, a thin line runs from the label to the part.

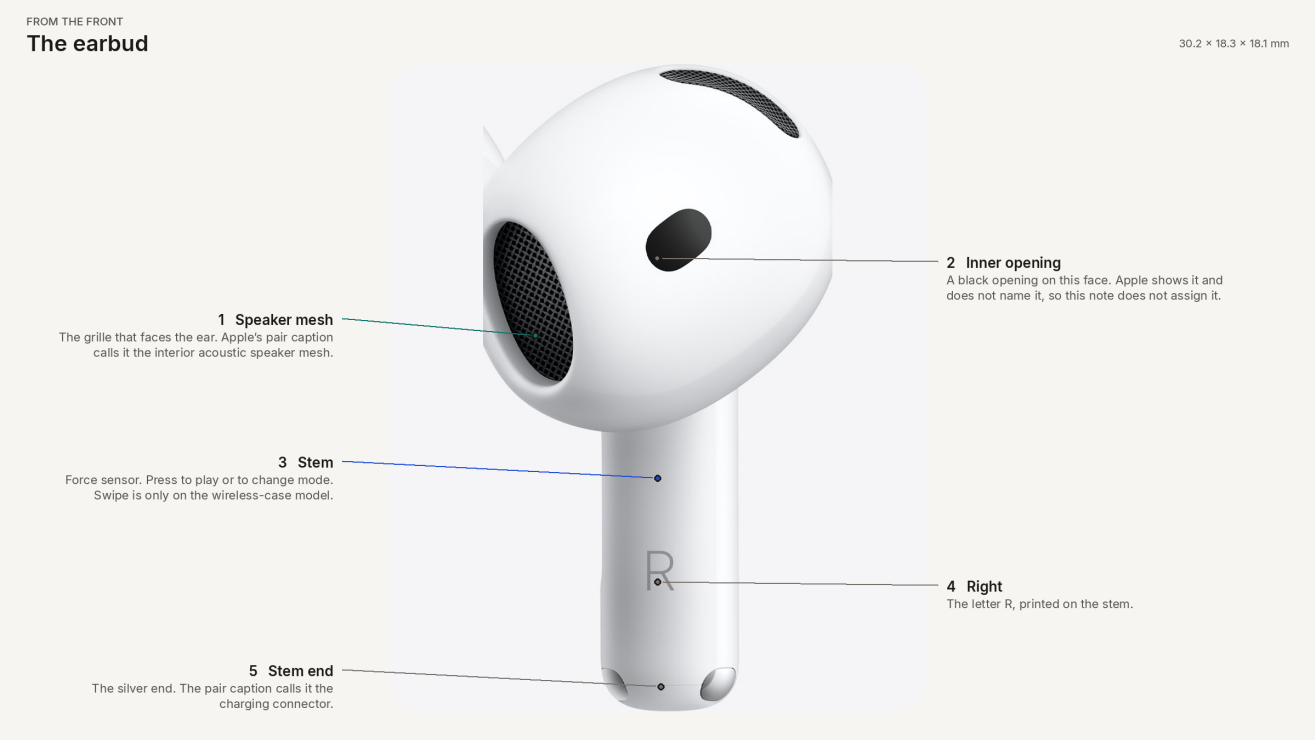
AirPods 5

A research note on the regular AirPods, not AirPods Pro. Two versions share the earbud shape. The wireless charging case adds battery life, a case speaker, and volume swipe. Active Noise Cancellation is on both.

Announced 9 September 2026. In stores 18 September 2026. 129 US dollars with the USB-C case, 149 US dollars with the Wireless Charging Case. H2 in each earbud, Bluetooth 5.3, IP57 on the earbuds and the case. Each earbud is 30.2 × 18.3 × 18.1 mm and weighs 4.3 g. There is no ear tip. Nothing here was measured on hardware in this project. Where Apple does not publish a number, the number is left out.

What each part is

Each plate is one of Apple’s own photographs or Apple’s own interior drawing. A thin line runs from the label to the part. The black opening on the inner face is visible and unnamed, so it stays unnamed. The millimetre figures are Apple’s published overall sizes, the same for both versions of the earbud.

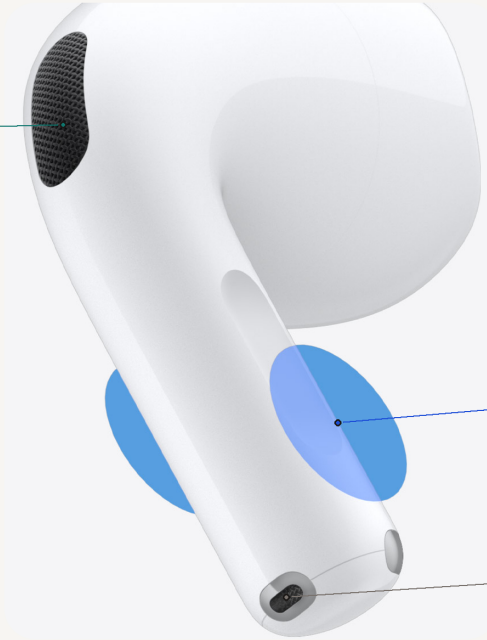




THE STEM

The control surface

No mechanical button



2 Speaker mesh
The edge of the speaker grille.

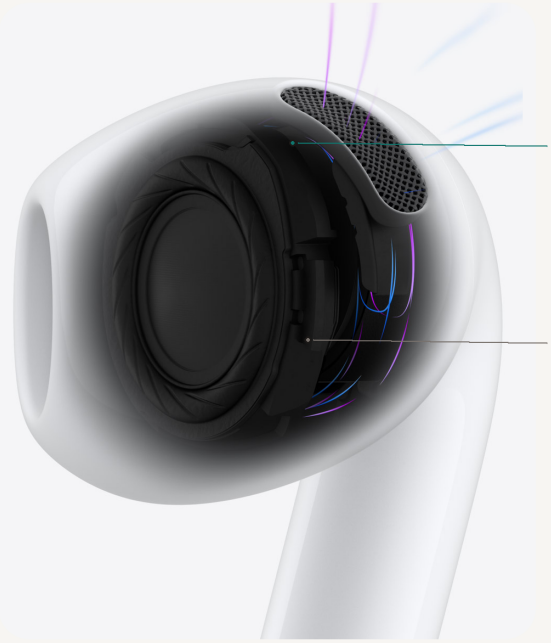
1 Volume swipe
The blue area is Apple's own mark for where to swipe. It is on AirPods 5 with Wireless Charging Case.

3 Stem end
The end of the stem. A close-up on Apple's page captions this opening as the external stem microphone.

APPLE'S INTERIOR DRAWING

The driver

Open ear, no tip



2 Speaker mesh
Apple's caption says the coloured lines are air and sound coming through the earbud. They are not a measurement.

1 Driver
The round speaker. Apple calls it a custom high-excursion driver. Diameter unpublished.

APPLE'S DRAWING

Inside the stem

H2 in each earbud



1 H2
Apple prints the name on this image. One H2 in each earbud.

2 Stem end
The port at the end of the stem, in the same drawing.

CLOSED

The case

46.2 × 50.1 × 21.2 mm



1 Status light
The green point on the front. This frame is the wireless charging case.

How to read the figures

Blue is Active Noise Cancellation. Stone is the open fit with noise control off. This model has no foam seal, so stone is not a tip. Apple has not published a hearing-protection datasheet for AirPods 5 in the sources read for this note, so there is no ANSI total and no octave-band table here. The laboratory curves are one fixture, and they are a different kind of decibel from Apple's "up to 50 percent more" sentence.

Apple says AirPods 5 remove up to 50 percent more external noise than AirPods 4 with Active Noise Cancellation. The separate "best in class" claim is an IEC 60268-24 test from July 2026, on an iPhone 17 with prerelease firmware and iOS 27, against the best-selling wireless open-ear headphones then on sale. This note does not turn 50 percent into a decibel. A doubling of acoustic power is 3 dB. A sound that seems about half as loud is closer to 10 dB.

What active cancellation adds, by frequency

Stone is the open fit with ANC off. Blue is ANC on. There is no silicone tip, so the low end has almost no passive block.

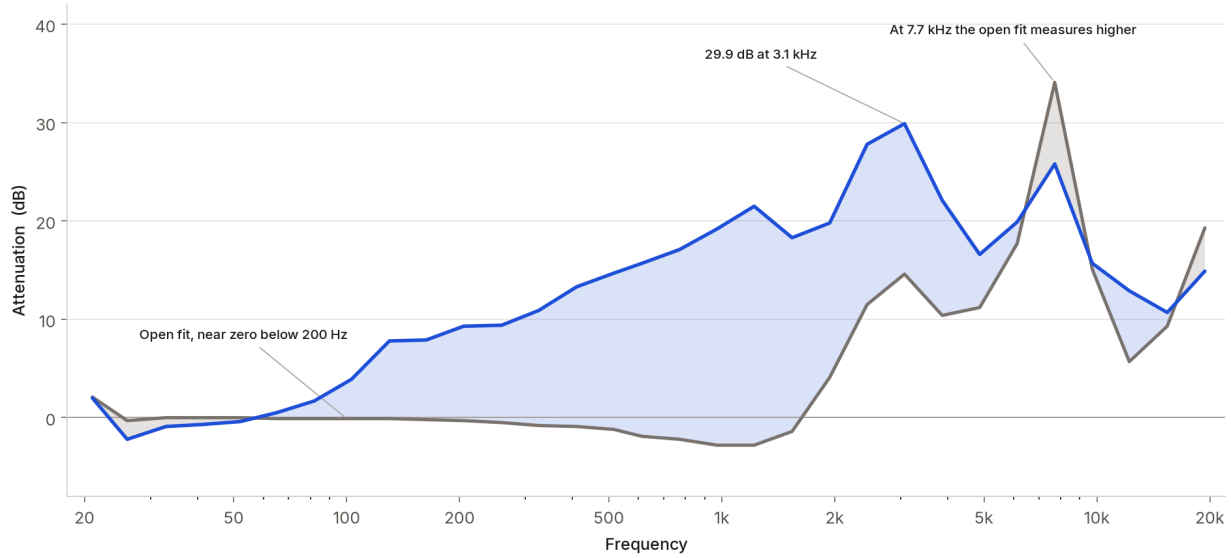


Figure 1 SoundGuys B&K 5128, AirPods 5 with Wireless Charging Case. Decibels of outside noise blocked. Not Apple's hearing-protection test. Fit changes an open earbud.

Below about 200 Hz the open fit blocks essentially nothing, and a few points sit slightly below zero. ANC is what creates the block through the mids: 29.9 dB at 3.1 kHz on this sweep. At 7.7 kHz the open fit alone measured 34.1 dB and ANC on measured 25.8 dB, so cancellation is not more blocking at every frequency. SoundGuys also reports a 59 percent reduction in perceived loudness, against 53 percent for AirPods 4 with ANC. That is their average, not Apple's 50 percent.

Playback against a preference target

Zero is the SoundGuys target, not silence. The open fit drops the bass. The three-band Custom EQ is a separate control, and Apple does not publish its range.

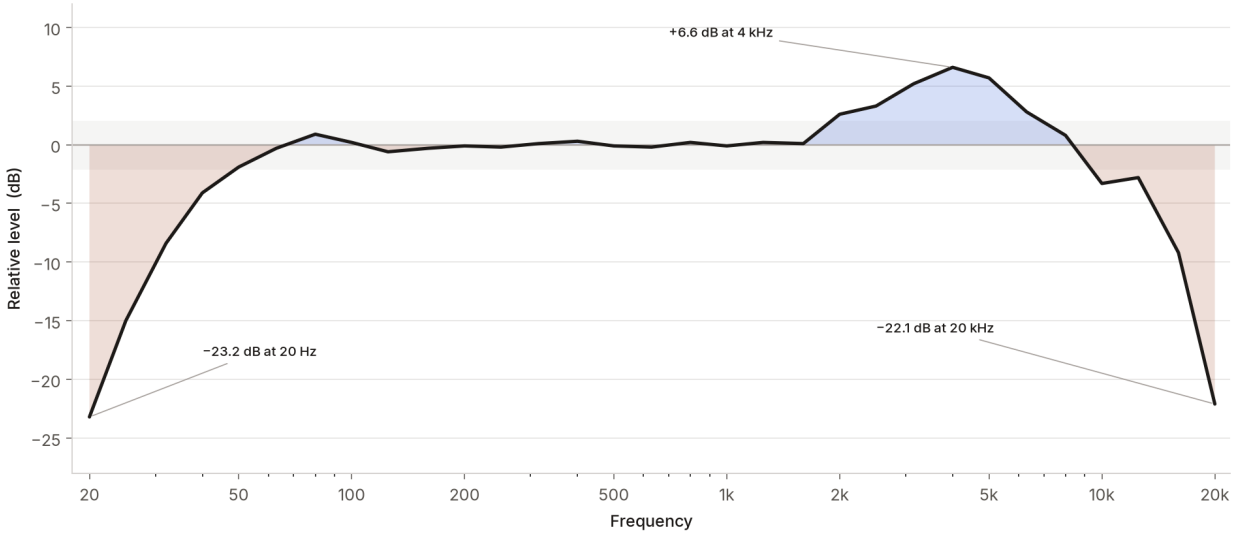


Figure 2 SoundGuys B&K 5128, relative to their preference curve. The same wireless-case model. Not an Apple specification.

From 80 Hz to about 1.6 kHz the curve sits within about 1 dB of the lab target. The bass does not: −8.4 dB at 32 Hz and −23.2 dB at 20 Hz. There is a lift of 6.6 dB at 4 kHz, then a fall to −22.1 dB at 20 kHz. Adaptive EQ still runs from the inward microphone. Separately, iOS 27 adds three sliders, Low, Mid, and High, on AirPods 4 or later, stored on the earbuds. Apple does not publish their decibel range, their center frequencies, or a Q.

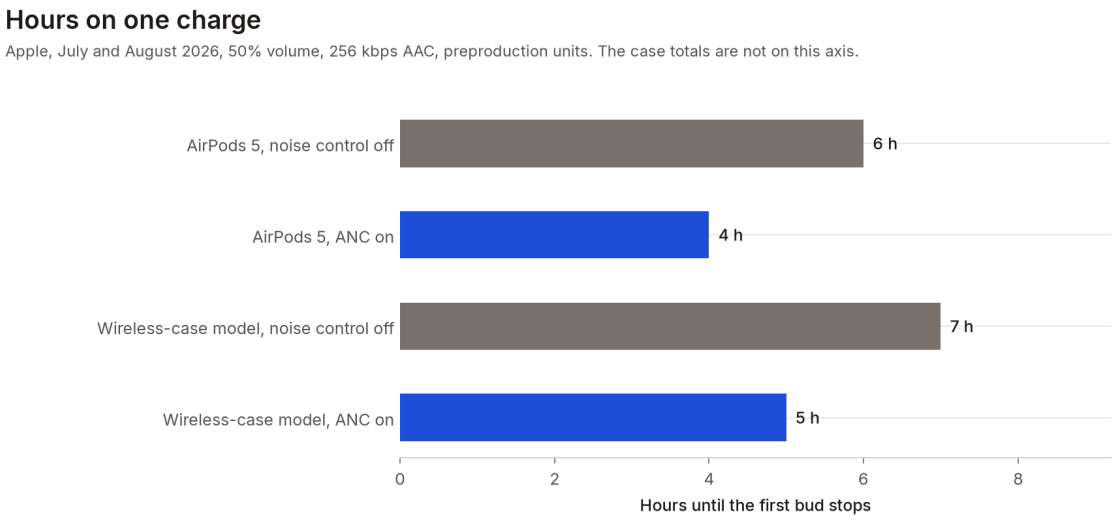


Figure 3 Stone is noise control off. Blue is ANC. Not drawn: 20 h with the USB-C case, 22 h with the wireless case, both with ANC. Five minutes in the case is about 1 h.

The USB-C model is 4 hours with ANC and 6 hours with noise control off. The wireless-case model is 5 hours with ANC and 7 hours with noise control off, one hour longer on ANC than AirPods 4 with ANC. With the case those ANC totals are 20 hours and 22 hours. Five minutes in either case is about one hour, and that quick-charge test was run with noise control off. The two earbuds are not interchangeable: each case fits only its own model.

Controls, in short

Press once to play or pause, answer a call, mute or unmute, or use the camera remote. Press twice to skip forward or end a call. Press three times to skip back. Mute and end-call can be swapped between one press and two. Press and hold switches Active Noise Cancellation, Transparency, and Adaptive Audio, and either stem can be set to Siri instead. Hold both stems for Live Translation. Say “Siri” or “Hey Siri”. Nod or shake only if Announce Calls and Announce Notifications are on. Swipe for volume exists only on AirPods 5 with Wireless Charging Case. Apple does not publish how many decibels one swipe moves.

What this note does not claim

No driver diameter, no official frequency-response curve, no official ANC curve, no sample rate for studio-quality recording, and no hearing-aid or heart-rate feature on the spec page. No MagSafe on either case. No ear tips. The three Custom EQ sliders have no published range. An Android phone can play audio and the stem still works, and there is no supported Apple API for an app to write ANC, EQ, or gestures. The photographs and plates are Apple’s.